the screen ‘buzzing’ at all times, almost as if it is a flight schedule monitor at the airport. Breathless urgency is our stock-in-trade, crises and triumphs only as durable as the thirty-minute news bulletin that rolls out every hour. When I joined television in 1994, I got a full week to do my first story for *The World This Week*. Now, a reporter is expected to deliver a story in a couple of hours. A certain frenetic mindlessness has crept in, driven perhaps by what I call the demands of a ‘sound bite society’.

In this manic environment, there is still the hunger for being ‘first’ on air. In particular, who would get the first interviews with the two main actors of the election—Narendra Modi and Rahul Gandhi. The Rahul battle was won, fairly and squarely, by my former colleague at NDTV and now editor in chief of Times Now, Arnab Goswami. Arnab and I go back a fairly long way. I remember a slim, floppy-haired, bespectacled youngster visiting my home in the early 1990s to inquire about TV opportunities. I had then been a mentor of sorts to him. We worked together for almost a decade and had even co-anchored a show. But television news can be maddeningly competitive, and a personal relationship based on mutual respect can easily descend into a slightly troubled professional equation revolving around constant one-upmanship. Arnab’s ‘nation wants to know’ rumbustious style of anchoring had won him a lot of fans; I found it, at times, disturbingly chaotic and sensationalist.

The backstory of the Rahul interview reflects some of the cross currents in modern-day TV journalism. Several news channels had been hounding Rahul’s office with requests for an interview. Barkha Dutt, another star anchor and also a former colleague at NDTV, had been promised the first interview. She had met Rahul and Priyanka in December 2013 and an ‘agreement’ had been reached. NDTV is seen as occupying a politically left-liberal space—a channel that perhaps the Congress leader felt comfortable talking to. A date, 12 January, was also fixed for the interview. The channel’s producers even went to the location—Jawahar Bhavan, home to the Rajiv Gandhi Foundation—and worked on the lights and camera positioning.